

MASTERCLASS

AI Prompt Engineering Masterclass

Master the art of talking to AI — from basic prompts to advanced techniques that get professional results every time.

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What Is Prompt Engineering?

Prompt engineering is the skill of communicating with AI models to get the results you actually want. It is the difference between an AI that gives you generic, mediocre output and one that produces work you can actually use.

The good news: you do not need a computer science degree to get good at this. You need to understand a few key principles and practice applying them. This guide teaches you everything you need to go from beginner to advanced.

■ Pro Tip

The single biggest improvement most people can make to their prompts: be more specific.
"Write a blog post about coffee" → "Write a 1,200-word blog post about the health benefits of black coffee for office workers aged 30-45, citing 3 recent studies, in a conversational but professional tone."

The 5 Core Principles

1. Specificity Beats Brevity

The more specific your prompt, the better the output. Short prompts get short, generic answers. Detailed prompts get detailed, specific answers. This feels counterintuitive — we are trained to be concise — but with AI, more context is almost always better.

Weak: "Write a product description" Strong: "Write a 100-word product description for a \$49 standing desk mat targeted at remote workers who experience lower back pain. Emphasize the anti-fatigue benefits, use second-person voice, and end with a call to action."

2. Role Assignment Changes Everything

Telling the AI what role to play dramatically changes the quality and style of its output. "You are a senior marketing consultant with 15 years of experience in SaaS..." produces different (and usually better) output than just asking a question directly.

The role sets expectations for expertise level, tone, and approach. Use it for any task where professional knowledge matters.

3. Examples Are More Powerful Than Instructions

Showing the AI examples of what you want is more effective than describing what you want. This is called few-shot prompting.

Instead of: "Write in a casual, friendly tone" Try: "Write in the style of these examples: [paste 2-3 examples of writing you like]"

The AI learns from patterns. Give it the pattern you want.

4. Chain of Thought for Complex Problems

For complex tasks, ask the AI to show its reasoning before giving an answer. This forces it to think more carefully and dramatically reduces errors.

Add "Think step by step" or "Show your reasoning before giving the final answer" to any prompt where accuracy matters — math problems, logical reasoning, research analysis, decision-making.

5. Iteration Is the Secret

Professional prompt engineers rarely get perfect results on the first try. They iterate. They start with a basic prompt, evaluate the output, and refine.

The process: write prompt → evaluate output → identify what is wrong → refine prompt → repeat.
Three rounds of iteration produces dramatically better results than one perfect prompt attempt.

Advanced Prompting Techniques

The RISEN Framework

A structured formula for professional prompts:

Role: "You are a [specific role]" Instructions: "Your task is to [specific task]" Steps: "Follow these steps: [numbered steps]" End goal: "The final output should be [description]" Narrowing: "Constraints: [limitations, format, length, tone]"

Example: "You are a senior UX writer with experience at top tech companies. Your task is to rewrite the onboarding copy for a project management app. Follow these steps: 1) Review the copy I provide 2) Identify confusing jargon 3) Rewrite each section in plain English. The final output should be a side-by-side comparison of old and new copy. Constraints: Keep the same structure, do not add new sections, target reading level: grade 8."

The Persona Technique

Assign a detailed persona to the AI — not just a job title, but a full character with specific experience, knowledge, and perspective.

Weak persona: "You are a marketing expert" Strong persona: "You are Sarah Chen, a B2B SaaS marketing director with 12 years of experience. You have led growth at three companies from Series A to acquisition. You are known for data-driven decision making and skepticism toward vanity metrics. You communicate in clear, direct language and always tie recommendations to business outcomes."

The more specific the persona, the more consistent and expert-level the output.

Negative Prompting

Tell the AI explicitly what NOT to do. This is as important as telling it what to do.

Examples of useful negative constraints: - "Do not use buzzwords like synergy, leverage, or paradigm shift" - "Do not start with I" - "Do not add disclaimers or caveats unless they are essential" - "Do not repeat information that has already been stated" - "Do not write in passive voice"

Negative constraints are especially useful when you have received outputs with specific flaws you want to avoid.

The Decomposition Technique

For complex tasks, break them into smaller sub-tasks and handle each separately. This is more reliable than trying to do everything in one massive prompt.

Instead of: "Write a complete marketing strategy for my app"

Try: Prompt 1: "Define the target audience for [app]" Prompt 2: "Using this target audience [paste output], identify the top 3 marketing channels" Prompt 3: "For each channel, write a 90-day action plan" Prompt 4: "Synthesize these into an executive summary"

Each step builds on the previous one, and you can review and correct at each stage.

Temperature Control via Prompting

You cannot directly control model temperature in most interfaces, but you can influence it through your prompt language.

For creative, varied output: "Be creative and unexpected. Surprise me. Avoid the obvious answer."

For precise, consistent output: "Be precise and conservative. Stick to established facts. Do not speculate."

For a balance: "Be creative but grounded. Offer original ideas that are still practical and evidence-based."

50 Prompt Templates by Use Case

These templates work across ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and most major AI models. Replace [bracketed text] with your specific information.

Writing & Editing

Rewrite this text to be [50% shorter / more formal / more conversational / at a grade 8 reading level]: [paste text]

Write a [type] in the voice and style of [author/publication]. Here are 3 examples of their writing: [paste examples]. Now write about: [topic]

Edit this draft for [clarity / conciseness / tone / grammar]. Explain every change you make: [paste draft]

Write 5 different introductions for this article, each using a different hook technique (question, statistic, story, bold statement, counterintuitive claim): [paste article]

This paragraph is too long and dense. Break it into shorter paragraphs, add subheadings where appropriate, and use bullet points for any list items: [paste paragraph]

Analysis & Research

Analyze this data and tell me: 1) The 3 most important insights, 2) What the data does NOT tell us, 3) What action you would recommend based on this: [paste data]

Play devil's advocate against this argument. What are the strongest possible counterarguments? What evidence would someone use to refute this?: [paste argument]

Compare [Option A] and [Option B] for someone who is [describe your situation]. Focus on [these specific factors]. Recommend one and explain why.

Summarize this research paper for a non-technical executive audience. Include: main finding, methodology in 2 sentences, practical implications, limitations: [paste paper]

I believe [your belief]. What am I missing? What are the strongest arguments against this position?

Strategy & Planning

Create a 90-day plan to achieve [goal]. I have [hours per week] available, [describe resources], and [describe constraints]. Be realistic, not aspirational.

What are the 3 highest-leverage actions I could take to [desired outcome]? For each, estimate the effort required and the expected impact.

I am trying to decide between [Option A] and [Option B]. The most important factors to me are [list factors]. What decision would you recommend and why?

Identify the assumptions behind this plan and rate each one from high to low risk: [paste plan]. What would need to be true for this plan to work?

I want to [goal]. What are the 5 biggest obstacles I will face and how should I prepare for each?

Communication

Rewrite this email to be more [direct / diplomatic / persuasive / concise]. Keep the core message but improve the tone: [paste email]

I need to have a difficult conversation with [person] about [topic]. Help me prepare: what should I say first, what objections should I expect, and how should I respond to each?

Write a response to this negative review that: acknowledges the customer's experience, does not admit liability, offers a specific resolution, and maintains a professional tone: [paste review]

Turn this technical explanation into something a non-technical client can understand. No jargon. Use analogies where helpful: [paste technical content]

Write talking points for a 5-minute presentation about [topic] to [audience]. Include: opening hook, 3 main points with one supporting fact each, memorable closing statement.

Productivity & Personal

I have these tasks to complete today: [list tasks]. I have [X hours] available. Help me prioritize them using the Eisenhower Matrix and create a time-blocked schedule.

I am procrastinating on [task]. Diagnose why I might be avoiding it and give me a concrete first action that takes less than 5 minutes to start.

Teach me [concept] using the Feynman technique – explain it as if I am a complete beginner, use a simple analogy, then build to the more complex version.

I just received this feedback: [paste feedback]. Help me separate the valid criticism from the noise and create an action plan based only on the actionable points.

What questions should I be asking about [topic] that I am not thinking to ask? What do experts in this field consider obvious that beginners typically miss?

Common Prompt Engineering Mistakes

■ Being too vague

The most common mistake. "Write something about AI" is not a prompt — it is a wish. Be specific about topic, audience, format, length, tone, and purpose.

■ Accepting the first output

The first output is a draft. Respond with feedback: "This is good but too formal — rewrite it in a more conversational tone." Iteration is not failure; it is the process.

■ Not providing context

AI models do not know who you are, what your business does, who your audience is, or what success looks like for you. Provide this context explicitly in your prompt.

■ Asking too many things at once

Complex multi-part prompts produce unfocused outputs. Ask one thing at a time, then build on each response.

■ Anthropomorphizing the AI

AI models do not have opinions, preferences, or feelings. Phrases like "do you think" or "what do you prefer" get you unpredictable results. Ask for analysis and options, not opinions.

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